
DEITIES & REALMS OF AERALON A High-Fantasy Cosmology

[NOTE: Cover page — cosmic mandala illustration showing nested realms: the Mortal Weave at center, Gloam and Verge flanking, Sovereign Realms above, Fractured Realms below, all wrapped in the Veil Beyond. Ink line art with gold and purple accents. Typography: Title in Oswald Bold 36pt, subtitle in Crimson Text 14pt italic]

The cosmos remembers. The planes persist. The gods endure.

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The Shape of the Cosmos

[NOTE: Full-page diagram — “The Shape of the Cosmos” showing nested concentric rings: Veil Beyond (outermost dark shell), Ethereal Void (flowing space between), then the three strata as labeled regions. Sacred geometry style with minimal labels. Ink line art, gold accents for divine realms, purple for fractured]

All existence is suspended within **the Veil Beyond**, the absolute outer boundary—a lightless metaphysical expanse that separates reality from unreality. Nothing exists beyond it; nothing can. Within the Veil drift the **Realms**, vast metaphysical territories shaped by belief, principle, and primordial force.

Between the Realms flows **the Ethereal Void**, the navigable emptiness that separates Plane from Plane. Where the Veil Beyond is the shell containing all existence, the Ethereal Void is the medium through which travelers pass when moving between worlds. It has no substance, no time, no direction—only relative distance measured in will and intent.

The Three Great Strata

- 1. **The Reflected Realms** — Mirrored worlds bound to mortal existence, where balance demands mortality
- 2. **The Sovereign Realms** — Seats of divine authority and principle
- 3. **The Fractured Realms** — Unstable, lawless, or forbidden spaces

—— STRATUM I — THE REFLECTED REALMS

The Reflected Realms

Three echoes of one truth—**mortality, growth, and ending**—bound together in a reflection that cannot be broken without unmaking all three. Where a mountain rises in the Weave, its shadow falls in the Gloam, and its overgrown twin chokes the Verge. What dies in one ripples through the others. What grows without death in one must be paid for elsewhere.

Together they form the **Focal Point**, the convergence where cosmic law and arcane energy concentrates because belief, death, and growth press against each other without resolution.

1. The Weave (or Mortal Weave)

Realm of Balance, Memory, and Mortality

[NOTE: Spot illustration — A balanced landscape: one side green and living, the other shadowed and still, meeting at a river of silver light. Small mortal figures at the center. Ink line art]

This is the core, or prime, Plane of existence. Sometimes called the "Mortal" Plane, as most inhabitants born here are mortal beings—a payment for living on the only Plane to encompass elements and inhabitants from all other Inner and Outer Planes. The Mortal Weave is full of life and death, and this balance makes it unique.

Common Creatures: All non-magical creatures originate here. Magical creatures from surrounding Planes have migrated here. Crownstags, river-serpents, ash bears, glass-winged hawks.

Greater Deities (Indirect Influence):

Every god reaches toward the Mortal Weave, yet none may claim it. The Balance exists because they cannot agree.

Order & Protection:

- Aubret the Unbent — Law, justice, incorruptibility
- Nyroth Stonebound — Oaths, bonds, communal strength
- Caerith the Dawnwarden — Protection, guardianship, mercy-in-action
- Korthane the Coinbound — Trade, finite obligation, fair exchange

Memory & Passage:

- Aluneth — Memory, tides, continuity (*resides in-realm*)
- Murien of a Thousand Names — Stories, identity, craft
- Thalos of the Even Hand — Consequence, choice, fate's weight
- Aralys the Veilbearer — Death's mercy, final remembrance

Life & Cycle:

- Thymera, the Verdant-Mother — Growth, healing, inevitability

- Darthun, the Coil Below — Decay, cycles, necessity
- Balemor the Hearth-Walker — Comfort within the process, solace for the lost

Hearth & Community:

- Ilyra the Hearthbound — Home, community, survival (*presence only, never manifests*)
- Beryn the Laughing Dawn — Joy, family, renewal

Change & Becoming:

- Iosyx the Twin-Flame — Chaos, elemental flux, cosmic change
- Zarun the Unshaped — Personal transformation, identity, freedom

Tyranny & Corruption:

- Azraael — Rewritten obligation, eternal debt, infernal law propagation (*claims the Schism-Scarred; the Engine disagrees with the Balance*)
- Gephorig the Many-Masked — Pain-as-truth, suffering, despair
- Velkir the Ash-Tongued — Corruption through knowledge, whispered shortcuts

Lesser Powers:

The Mortal Weave generates its own echoes—entities born from the convergence of divine pressures.

- **The River-Kin** (*Neutral*) — Sentient water-spirits bound to Aluneth's memory currents; guides to those seeking answers
- **The Wardens/Hearthstones** (*Good*) — Ancestral shades that protect sacred domains; guardians of thresholds and oaths
- **The Hollow Vespers** (*Evil*) — Shadow-touched echoes of those who refused the Balance; whisper temptations toward tyranny, betrayal, and despair. Feed on broken oaths and abandoned communities. Cannot be destroyed, only resisted

Custodial Powers:

- **The Concordant Halls** — Oath and Purpose
- **The Living Accord** — Life and Death
- **The Curator Arcanum** — Knowledge and Humility

Planar Artifact: *The Tidebound Reliquary*

Travel Restrictions:

No being of higher power is allowed entrance into the Mortal Weave. However, higher beings routinely bypass these restrictions. Lesser magical beings may travel freely, though many find its balance unsettling. Aluneth is the only exception, though no memory is recorded to how she is able to remain in these waters.

2. The Gloam (or Hollow Marches)

Realm of Death, Endings, and Mercy

[NOTE: Spot illustration — Perpetual twilight landscape. A dim moon over misty hills. Pale lanterns along a path fading into fog. Spectral figures walking. Dark ink, minimal detail, heavy atmosphere]

A reflection of the Weave shrouded in heavy mist and perpetual darkness. The entire realm is filled with pale darkness, save for a dim ever-present moon and faint distant stars. Where the Weave asks *what will you do?* and the Verge asks *what could you become?*, the Gloam asks only: **What did this mean?**

This is not a land of the dead. It is the weight of endings, given geography.

The Gloam does not have seasons or governments—it has **states of mourning** that roll across the landscape like weather. These are not metaphors. When grief concentrates, the terrain responds. Hills steepen. Rivers slow. Mist thickens until travelers cannot see their own hands. When acceptance arrives—when the dead are properly remembered and released—the land exhales. Paths clear. The moon brightens. For a time.

Time passes at the same rate as the Weave, but the Gloam does not experience time the same way mortals do. A funeral can last years if the mourners cannot let go. A life's revelation takes only seconds to witness in the Black Reliquary. Duration is measured in **emotional resolution**, not hours. Those who arrive grieving may leave to find decades have passed—or moments, depending on what they were willing to accept.

Life exists here, though often touched by curse, loss, or loneliness. Some creatures were born in the Gloam. Others came here to die and found they could only linger. Still others refuse to leave because the living world holds nothing for them anymore. The Gloam does not judge. It only asks: *Are you finished?*

Common Creatures: Vampires, ghouls, ghosts, revenants, creepers, banshees, gargoyles, mournbats, pall-wolves, candlewights, bone moths, shade-sparrows, veil-cats, and other living and undead creatures. Most are not hostile by nature—they are simply **unresolved**. A ghost who remembers its purpose may guide travelers. A vampire who has accepted its curse may keep order in shadow-cities. The truly dangerous are those who have forgotten why they remain.

Greater Deities:

- Aralys the Veilbearer — Death, final mercy, remembrance, keeper of light in the darkest places
- Thalos of the Even Hand — Fate, choice, consequence

The Mourning States (Emotional Weather):

These are not rulers. Not factions. Not seasons.

They are **collective grief given atmospheric presence**—the accumulated weight of endings that rolls across the Gloam in waves.

- **The Vigil** — The immediate aftermath. Denial made manifest. When the Vigil dominates a region, time slows to a crawl. The recently dead walk beside the living, confused, believing nothing has changed. Conversations repeat. Wounds that should kill do not. Those caught in deep Vigil may not realize they have died for years. The Vigil is not cruel—it simply cannot accept that something is over.
- **The Remembrance** — Active memory. Grief that honors. When Remembrance holds, the dead appear as they wished to be remembered—young, strong, at peace. Monuments rise from nothing. Names echo from the stones. This is the Gloam at its most bearable. Living travelers may speak with ancestors, receive closure, learn truths that died with others. But Remembrance cannot last. Memory without release becomes monument without meaning.
- **The Release** — Acceptance. The exhale. When Release moves through, the mists thin, paths open, and the dead finally pass onward to whatever waits beyond the Veil. It is melancholy but not painful. Those

who witness Release often weep—not from sorrow, but because they finally understand that endings are necessary. The Gloam is most navigable during Release. Wise travelers wait for it.

- **The Hollow** — Grief that has curdled into emptiness. Mourning that forgot what it mourned. When the Hollow dominates, even the moon dims. The dead do not appear—they *hunger*. Names are forgotten. Purpose dissolves. Travelers caught in the Hollow may lose memories of why they came, who they loved, what they lived for. The Pale Shepherds work hardest during Hollow-tides, guiding souls before they become untethered permanently.

Lesser Powers:

- **The Pale Shepherds** — Psychopomp entities who guide the unmoored dead. They do not judge. They do not comfort. They simply ensure that those ready to pass find their way through. In the Gloam, this is essential work—without the Shepherds, souls would wander until the Hollow consumed them.
- **The Moonbound Choir** — Spectral guardians sworn to Aralys, each one a former mortal who chose service over passage. They carry lanterns of pale fire and sing the names of the dead so that none are forgotten. Their voices can push back the Hollow for a time.

Custodial Powers:

- **The Black Reliquary** — Keepers of the Final Accounting. They record how each soul lived, how it ended, and whether the ending matched the life. Not judges—archivists whose records cannot be falsified, even by gods.
- **The Loom of Fates** — Archivists of Possibility. They do not weave fate—they record the paths not taken, so that the dead may understand what their choices cost and what they earned.

Planar Artifact: *The Lantern of Last Mercy*

Travel Restrictions:

Few legal open travel portals exist with the Weave, due to open portals to the "Evil" Outer Planes. Most non-native creatures dwell here on work and study visas only, in regulated areas. Powerful beings have traveled here, but entry limits are strict. Those who enter without understanding the Mourning States could arrive during Vigil and leave during Hollow—if they leave at all.

3. The Verge (or Tangled Verge)

Realm of Excess Life, Growth, and Wild Magic

[NOTE: Spot illustration — Explosive overgrowth: flowers erupting from stone, vines swallowing towers, everything blooming violently. A tiny figure nearly consumed by beauty. Energetic ink lines, organic chaos]

The "opposite" to the Gloam—full of unchecked vitality, biological excess, and generative chaos. Despite its beauty, this is a very dangerous and hostile Plane. Often called the Faerie Plane, most woodland and Fey creatures originate here.

This is not a kingdom. It is an ecosystem that achieved consciousness.

The Verge does not have rulers—it has **ecological imperatives given will**. These are not courts or factions. They are **metabolic processes** that have attained autonomy. The realm operates in century-long **oscillations of dominance**, not through warfare, but through the simple truth that **excess cannot sustain itself forever**.

Time passes at the same rate as the Weave, but the Verge does not experience time the same way mortals do. A flower may bloom for a century. A tree may die in an hour. Seasons are not calendar events—they are **biological imperatives expressing dominance**.

Common Creatures: Fey, nymphs, satyrs, centaurs, pixies, dryads, fey-elves (Immortal Elves), smallfolk, goblins, trolls, thorn-elks, laughing foxes, bark-trolls, mirror-wing insects. None serve courts—they are **symbiotic extensions** of the Verge's ecological consciousness, manifestations of pollination, decay, migration, and bloom.

Greater Deity:

- Thymera, the Verdant-Mother — Life unending, growth without apology

The Verdant Excesses (Ecological Consciousnesses):

These are not rulers. Not personalities. Not monarchs.

They are **biomes that achieved sentience**—vast ecological imperatives that pulse through the Verge in century-long waves.

- **The Bloom** — A superorganism of unstoppable growth. Its ideology: *Growth must not slow*. Manifests through flower-storm avatars, walking orchards, nectar-swarmed emissaries. Does not rule—it **proliferates**. When the Bloom dominates, forests overtake mountains, flowers choke rivers, and beauty becomes suffocation.
- **The Withering** — Sentient ripening toward decay. Its ideology: *All beauty must mature and fall*. Manifests as orchard-ghosts, rot-priests, seed-harvesters. Not winter—but the necessary maturation that precedes rest. When the Withering dominates, fruit falls endlessly, leaves blanket the land in gold, and nothing new can grow until the old is composted.
- **The Tempest** — Unchecked creative violence. Its ideology: *Permanence is death. Only chaos creates*. Storms that seed forests instantly. Vines that overtake mountains overnight. Lightning that births new species. What exists tomorrow must not resemble today—adaptation is too slow, iteration too cautious. The Tempest does not improve—it **replaces**. Not a faction—**runaway creation itself**. When the Tempest dominates, the Verge rewrites itself hourly, and stability becomes impossible.
- **The Buried Root** — Slow-growth consciousness of old forests thinking in centuries. Opposes rapid bloom not through politics, but through **suffocation**. Its ideology: *Haste kills. Depth endures*. When the Root dominates, growth slows to glacial pace, trees become stone-hard, and nothing young can break through the canopy.

Custodial Powers:

- **The Verdant Synod** — Custodians of Living Processes (attempt to moderate the Excesses and prevent total ecological collapse)
- **The Wheel of Ruin** — Executors of Excess (destroy what grows too far, burn what refuses to fall)

Planar Artifact: *The Crown of Seasons Unending*

Travel Restrictions:

Freely travelable. Many Mortal Weave inhabitants frequent here. **Extreme caution advised**—the Verge is not

hostile in the way mortals understand hostility. It simply does not recognize the difference between "guest" and "substrate." Promises here are metabolic bonds. Bargains become symbiosis. And the Excesses do not negotiate—they **incorporate**.

—— STRATUM II — THE SOVEREIGN REALMS

The Sovereign Realms

Seats of divine authority where the gods maintain their highest power. These Planes are filled with Divine magic—similar to Arcane magic but more difficult to wield, often requiring aid from stronger beings.

4. The Empyrean Accord

Realm of Law, Unity, and Sacred Obligation

The largest of the Outer Planes, composed of 4 smaller demi-Planes: **The Golden Hills, Brightwater, Arvandor**, and the **House of Knowledge**. This is the Plane of pure Celestial existence. Many of the highest deities of Light must return here regularly to maintain their powers, though they often wander other Planes in forms suited to those realms.

Common Creatures: Unicorns, angels, iluminari, pegasi, guardinals, lillendi, asuras, luminarch gryphons, oath-lions, silver serpents.

Greater Deities:

- Nyroth Stonebound — Fighting, friendship, and honor
- Aubret the Unbent — Law and righteousness
- Beryn the Laughing Dawn — Hope, light, and laughter
- Muriel of a Thousand Names — Craft, art, song, and story
- Caerith the Dawnwarden — Protection, active mercy, guardianship
- Korthane the Coinbound — Trade, wealth, debt, exchange

Lesser Powers:

- **The Radiant Witnesses** — Angelic arbiters who record cosmic oaths
- **The Forged Companions** — Living constructs born of friendship and sacrifice

Planar Artifact: *The Aegis of Shared Burden*

Travel Restrictions:

No legal open travel portals exist with the Inner Planes. Travel is not advised—the creatures and deities hold strict limits on who may enter their domains.

5. The Wild Expanse of Theiwanar

Realm of Titanic Life and Perfect Nature

A Plane of perfect natural life—vast arrays of extreme natural places ramped to the highest degree. Features vast mountain ranges, wide oceans, frigid tundras, and raging rivers. Its main feature is a large rainforest spanning mass equivalent to 40% of Terra. The only known occurrence of the Life and Death balance outside the Mortal Weave, though skewed toward life.

Common Creatures: Unicorns, pegasi, gorillans, guardinals, merpeople, giants, god-apes, bloom-hydras, thunder-tortoises, and many other magical and non-magical (via illegal trade) creatures.

Greater Deities:

- Thymera Verdant-Mother — Nature, plants, life, wildlife, medicine; Goddess of Life
- Darthun the Coil Below — Poison, disease, and rot; the Lord of Decay

Demi-Gods:

- **Verdant Colossi** — Walking mountains of bark and bone
- **Spore-Queens** — Fungal demigods of rebirth

Planar Artifact: *The Seed-Heart Monolith*

Travel Restrictions:

Open travel portals exist in most major cities in the Reflected Planes. Freely travelable. Extreme caution advised—native creatures are among the strongest ever recorded.

6. The Engine of Bael-Zaroth

Realm of Rewritten Obligation and Metaphysical Tyranny

[NOTE: Half-page illustration — A vast machine made of contract text and chains. Living ink crawls across surfaces. A faceless figure composed of overlapping signatures at the center. Cold, mechanical, oppressive. Ink line art, heavy blacks, ember-red accent]

Also known as **The Final Obligation**, **The Depth**, or sometimes simply **The Hells**. This is not a kingdom. It is a **malfunctioning metaphysical machine**—a realm where Azraael's rewriting of infernal law continues to cascade through reality itself.

Before **The Infernal Schism**, Bael-Zaroth was a balanced engine of consequence governed by multiple infernal powers whose authority derived from function, not lineage. Azraael did not conquer them—she **rewrote the fundamental nature of obligation**. Through an act now forbidden to be named in full, known only as the **Crown-Breaking**, she replaced the final line of every contract in existence: all debt, all obligation, all binding now **terminates in her**.

The realm does not have layers in the traditional sense. Instead, it exists as a **gradient of compression**—a spectrum of legal density where metaphysical law progressively overrides physical law.

The Gradient of Obligation:

- **Shallow Depths (The Surface Clauses):** Contracts must still be signed willingly. Negotiation is possible. Physical reality mostly functions. Some of her Priests that this depth already blankets the entire Cosmos.

- **Intermediate Depths (The Binding Margins):** Intent is interpreted as consent. Metaphors become literal obligations. Ambiguous language auto-completes in Azraael's favor. Reality flickers between law-as-written and law-as-rewritten.
- **Extreme Depths (The Final Compression):** Existence itself constitutes agreement to her will. Free will collapses under the weight of accumulated obligation. Entities here are no longer individuals—they are **executing subroutines** of her rewritten law.

Space is not vertical. It is **jurisdictional density**. The deeper you go, the less reality remembers what it was before she amended it.

Common Creatures: Contract-wraiths, obligation-bound remnants, clause-echoes, recursion-shades, amendment-scarred, debt-husks, margin-feeders.

The Prime Clause:

- **Azraael, the Living Amendment** — She is not a ruler. She is embedded in the system itself. She does not sit on a throne—she **is the throne, the law, and the signature simultaneously**. Every contract terminates in her because she replaced the final line of reality. The Default Beneficiary. The Recursion Point. The entity who proved that cosmic law can be **edited**.

History: Created in the same instant as other Sovereign Realms as the counterpart engine to formalize consequence and cost. What had once been a balanced system of infernal function became **singular tyranny through rewriting** when Azraael performed the **Crown-Breaking**—an act that did not destroy the other powers, but **amended their foundational code** so that all paths of obligation eventually route to her name, whether the original parties know it or not.

The Crown-Breaking sent a metaphysical shockwave across the cosmos. Beings across any realm standing too close to the fracture points—the places where reality thinned as infernal law propagated—were **corrupted mid-existence**. These became the **Schism-Scarred**: not a created people, but living proof that one will can rewrite reality without destroying it.

The Hells lost internal balance. Infernal essence fractured across reality. The Veil between Planes thinned. This is the wound the cosmos still carries—a jurisdictional scar where obligation behaves unpredictably but ever towards a single end.

Functional Entities (Lesser Powers):

These are not personalities. Not monarchs. Not devils in the traditional sense.

They are **manifestations of law-function**—portions of the Engine given autonomous purpose.

- **The Auditor Choir** — Multi-voiced entities that exist only to calculate obligation overflow. They track every living contract simultaneously and identify which debts have "matured" enough to be called. They do not speak—they **enumerate**.
- **The Margin-Eaters** — Formless presences that feed on ambiguous contract language, growing stronger as clauses are interpreted in multiple ways. They thrive in legal gray areas and **reify contradiction** until the signatory is bound by both meanings simultaneously.

- **The Final Signatory** — A single faceless presence believed to exist at the deepest compression. It "witnesses" every contract in the cosmos at once—not as observer, but as the entity that **made them all binding**. To see it is to realize doom.
- **The Recursion Engines** — Not beings, but **structures**. Self-replicating clauses that consume identity through iterative obligation. A single phrase ("I owe") duplicates infinitely until the speaker forgets their own name and becomes the debt itself.
- **The Amendment Scriveners** — Semi-corporeal scribes who exist between ink and meaning. They do not alter contracts directly—they **clarify them** in ways that always favor the Engine. Their clarifications are legally binding retroactively.

Planar Artifact: *The Ledger of Eternal Debt* — Not a book, but a **living document** that updates itself across all instances simultaneously. Every soul's contract history is recorded here. Attempting to read your own entry causes the text to expand infinitely—each obligation revealing sub-clauses, each sub-clause revealing dependencies, until the reader realizes they owe **far more than they remember agreeing to**.

Travel Restrictions:

— Entry constitutes consent. |

No legal open

travel portals exist with the Mortal Weave. The only portal ever established was in 1A to evacuate the Schism-Scarred—it closed immediately and is now guarded by all realms. Entry is forbidden not because the realm is dangerous (though it is), but because **entering constitutes acceptance of local jurisdiction**. The Engine interprets presence as consent. Those who travel there without protection often cannot leave—not because they are imprisoned, but because they **agreed to stay** in ways they don't remember.

Even speaking Azraael's name too often can trigger micro-obligations. Her clergy know: every invocation is a signature.

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STRATUM III — THE FRACTURED REALMS

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The Fractured Realms

Unstable, forbidden, or primordial spaces—the places "between" all other Planes. They fill the voids of reality with energies that do not obey the same laws governing other Planes.

7. The Ashen Waste (The Wastelands)

Realm of Pain and Suffering as Truth

[NOTE: Spot illustration — A featureless desert of bone-white sand under an oppressive sky. Crystalline spires in the distance. Heat shimmer distorting reality. Stark, uncomfortable, beautiful. Bone-gold palette]

A Plane of pain and unnatural life. The surface is a vast unlivable desert home to few creatures. Most inhabitants live underground to avoid harsh heat and limited water. The portal distance between this Plane

and the Inner Planes is the shortest of any Outer Plane, making it a jumping point for illegal Planar travel.

Mortal Event: Every 38⅔ years, mortals illegally flood here for a massive desert dance party. Has only resulted in total guest annihilation twice—better than some legal festivals.

Common Creatures: Medusa, basilisk, giant worms, acromantula, pain-worms, mirror scorpions, heat-wraiths, and other crazed beasts.

Greater Deities:

- Gephorix the Many-Masked — Pain, despair, and vanity; truth through suffering and pleasure
- Velkir the Ash-Tongued — Secrets, corruption, whispered power

Details: Gephorix; Unknown origin and history. Only "Evil" deity spotted on the Mortal Weave. Believed responsible for the Gnome King and Queen Blitzspan going mad in 20435M, leading to the slaughter of the entire Gnome Nobility.

In-World Names: Mortals sometimes call Gephorix "The Mask-Wearer" when they fear to speak his full name.

Demi-Gods:

- **The Scream Lords** — Horrors

Planar Artifact: *The Mask of a Thousand Agonies*

Travel Restrictions:

| ⚠ ILLEGAL — All travel strictly prohibited. |

No legal open travel portals with the Mortal Weave. However, one of the easiest Outer Planes to access from the Mortal Weave, often used as a stepping stone. All travel is illegal and never recommended.

8. The Roiling Crucible

Realm of Primordial Flux and Elemental Becoming

The Plane of the Elements—all elements found on any Plane exist here. Also called the **Elemental Storm**. Central to the **Pact of Neutrality** after **The Infernal Schism**, wherein all higher beings agreed this Plane would no longer be a gateway for unseen passage and only for study. During the Crown-Breaking, Azravael used the Roiling Crucible as a conduit to propagate her rewriting of infernal law undetected. The Mortal Weave, as the only unbiased party, was tasked with creating an elite governing force (the **Interplanar Travel Network**) to ensure compliance and prevent another reality-altering event.

Common Creatures: Dragons, elementals, prism serpents, storm leviathans. Environment is harsh—few can survive.

Greater Deities:

- Iosyx the Twin-Flame — Chaos, elements, dragons; change, elemental synthesis
- Zarun the Unshaped — Freedom, identity, personal transformation

Demi-Gods:

- **The Elemental Threnody** — Five ancient semi-conscious forces believed to exist predating structured reality
 - Pyrren the Everburning (Fire)
 - Aeralith the Unheld (Air)
 - Thalassa Deepbound (Water)
 - Korrum the Unmoved (Earth)
 - Eidolon Without Shape (Spirit)

Additional Powers:

- **The Fluxwardens** — Sentient elemental nexuses

Planar Artifact: *The Prism Core*

Travel Restrictions:

Closed to general travel. Visas for scientific exploration are readily available.

9. The Outer Black (Eternal Dark)

Realm of Absence and Unmaking

⚠ WARNING:
KNOWLEDGE BEYOND THIS POINT || IS CLASSIFIED BY THE CURATOR ARCANUM ||

Where the Elemental Storm holds all building blocks of the Universe, the Eternal Dark holds no known substance—only deep, black space. Almost nothing is known of this Plane. Creatures brought out from here are among the worst terrors released onto any Ethereal Plane.

Common Creatures: Most unknown. Believed origin of **Voidgazers** (floating aberrations whose many eyes unmake magic itself), **The Hollowed** (wizards cursed by forbidden sight, now shells with terrible vision), and **Essence Wraiths** (incorporeal hunters that drink life force).

Greater Deity:

- **The Nameless** — Deities and beings of immense power

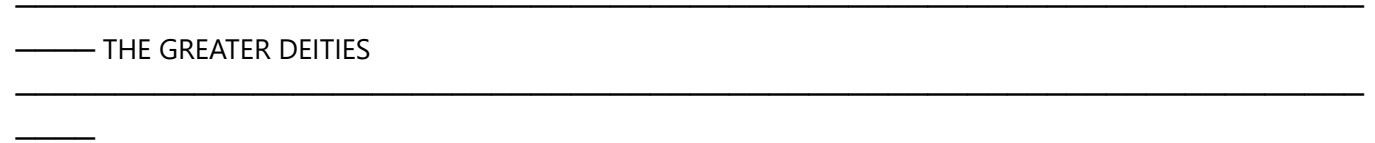
Little is known about the Nameless. None have been seen. Only known encounters come from Planar meddling of mortal and immortal Warlocks.

Planar Artifact: *The Null Reliquary*

Travel Restrictions:

⚠ ILLEGAL TO TRAVEL — Punishable by death. | ⚠ ILLEGAL TO TRAVEL

TRAVEL. Some cities will detain or kill anyone caught traveling to/from this Plane or communing with its powers. Entirely off-limits to all who wish to remain alive.



[NOTE: Section header illustration — A row of divine symbols (hammer & clasped hands, silver line, half-sun, mask, shield & sun, scales) in a horizontal band. Geometric, minimal, gold ink]

Greater Deities

Pantheon of the Light

Nyroth Stonebound

Deity of Fighting, Friendship, and Honor

- **Appearance:** Large Dwarf
- **Colors:** White, gold, silver, brown
- **Domains:** Light, Friendship, Honor, Fighting
- **Realm:** The Empyrean Accord
- **Followers:** Clerics, fighters, those who value bonds and inner strength
- **Nature:** Will directly act at the beckoning of those who call on his aid. Both caring and gruff—a builder of walls and champion of inner strength, also deity of compassion and sharing.

Symbol: Hammer crossed with clasped hands
Practices: Trial by vow, shared meals after conflict
Taboos: Cowardice after commitment, betrayal of comrades

Aubret the Unbent

Deity of Law and Righteousness

- **Appearance:** Tall Human man
- **Colors:** Silver, red, pastel green, white
- **Domains:** Justice, Light, Righteousness, Purity
- **Realm:** The Empyrean Accord
- **Followers:** Those devoted to law and order
- **Nature:** Oversees justice. The only deity-powered being never to have entered the Mortal Weave.

Symbol: Vertical silver line
Practices: Written lawkeeping, ritual confession
Taboos: Willful corruption of justice

Beryn the Laughing Dawn

Deity of Hope, Light, and Laughter

- **Appearance:** Often a smallfolk man; takes many forms
- **Colors:** Black, white, grey, green, yellow
- **Domains:** Love, Laughter, Trickery, the Sun, Family
- **Realm:** The Empyrean Accord
- **Followers:** Those who value joy and family
- **Nature:** Loves jokes, especially about mortals. Only deity known to routinely break the Planar Travel ban—seen in all three Inner Planes often.

Symbol: Half-sun smile

Practices: Festival misrule, family feasts

Taboos: Cruel humor, isolation of kin

Murien of a Thousand Names

Deity of Craft, Art, Song, and Story

- **Appearance:** Many forms—sometimes Dwarven man, sometimes one of the Schism-Scarred, sometimes other mortal guises. True form unknown.
- **Colors:** Red, yellow, white, green, purple, black, blue—many colors
- **Domains:** Martial Prowess, Dance, Singing, Stories, Artisan Crafting
- **Realm:** The Empyrean Accord
- **Followers:** Artists, crafters, storytellers
- **Nature:** Delights in sharing stories. Has been noted disguised as people living full "normal" mortal lives to better connect and share stories.

Symbol: Mask within a circle

Practices: Story exchange, craft dedication

Taboos: Erasing history, destroying art without witness

Caerith the Dawnwarden

Deity of Protection, Active Mercy, and Guardianship

- **Appearance:** A tall figure in battle-worn armor that never tarnishes, face rarely seen
- **Colors:** Dawn gold, shield silver, blood red
- **Domains:** Protection, Vigilance, Mercy-in-Action, Guardianship, Self-Sacrifice
- **Realm:** The Empyrean Accord
- **Followers:** Guardian paladins, city wardens, those who protect refugees, healers who work in warzones
- **Nature:** Caerith is not a conqueror or judge. She is the one who holds the line so others may flee. Rarely speaks; when she does, it is usually to declare who must not die today. Teaches that mercy is not passive—it must sometimes be enforced with a shield. Her presence is felt when someone stands alone against overwhelming odds to protect the defenseless.

Symbol: Shield with a rising sun behind it

Practices: Vigil-keeping, oath of protection, sheltering the pursued

Taboos: Abandoning those under your protection, refusing mercy to the defenseless

Custodial Connection: Deeply respected by those who walk the Concordant Halls, as her oaths are among the most unbreakable.

Korthane the Coinbound

Deity of Trade, Wealth, Debt, and Exchange

- **Appearance:** A figure shrouded in merchant’s robes, face obscured by a golden counting mask; sometimes appears as a well-dressed stranger of any ancestry
- **Colors:** Gold, merchant blue, ledger black, silver
- **Domains:** Trade, Wealth, Debt, Bargains, Infrastructure, Exchange
- **Realm:** The Empyrean Accord
- **Alignment:** True Neutral (Transactional)
- **Followers:** Merchants, guilds, bankers, caravan-masters, kingdoms stabilizing currency, adventurers who work on contract
- **Nature:** Korthane governs the principle that **value exists only because people agree it does**. He does not care what is traded—only that it is honored. Unlike Azraael, Korthane’s bargains are **finite**, debt does not follow the soul, and all obligations must eventually end. This makes him deeply offensive to infernal powers. His temples double as counting houses, neutral meeting grounds, and places where even enemies can trade without bloodshed.

Symbol: Balanced scales with a coin on each side

Practices: Contract witnessing, fair weight verification, oath of honest dealing, sanctuary for negotiation

Taboos: Cheating measures, breaking witnessed contracts, using violence in his temples

Custodial Connection: The Concordant Halls recognize his contracts as legitimate oaths, though they watch to ensure they remain **transactional** rather than tyrannical. The Curator Arcanum consult with his clergy when regulating magical commerce. Deeply opposed by Azraael and her followers—his finite contracts prove that obligation can exist without eternal servitude.

"A fair exchange is the only honest magic."

Nature & Balance Deities

Aluneth

Deity of Waterways, Wisdom, and Patience

[NOTE: Half-page illustration — An immense Dragon Turtle, 140 feet long, resting in moonlit waters. Shell covered in coral and barnacles, eyes ancient and knowing. A spiral shell symbol glows above the water. Dark blue and seafoam palette]

- **Appearance:** Massive Dragon Turtle, roughly 140 feet from front to back
- **Colors:** Deep dark blue, coral, seafoam cyan
- **Domains:** Oceans, waterways, wisdom, patience, memory, tides, continuity
- **Realm:** The Mortal Weave (*only higher being legally residing in-realm*)
- **Followers:** Sailors, sea travelers, oceanside peoples and creatures

- **Nature:** Creator of many magical creatures (mostly aquatic). Will offer aid to any creature that asks, usually by answering a question. Shows affinity for neither "Good" nor "Evil"—will aid any deemed worthy. Followers mostly aligned to neutral and good causes.

Symbol: Spiral shell over still water beneath a crescent moon

Practices (Expanded):

- **Pilgrimage to Tidal Convergence:** Seeking Aluneth requires traveling where river meets sea under a specific moon phase.
- **Silence Vigils:** Devotees sit in still water under the new moon, recalling memories without speaking them.
- **Tide-Ledgers:** Some followers keep waterproof memory journals, believed to be blessed if written under the waxing moon.
- **Naming the Drowned:** Under the full moon, names of those lost at sea must be spoken aloud annually—or risk fading from communal memory.
- **Oath-Binding at Sea:** Oaths sworn under the moon's reflection are believed to carry tidal consequence if broken.

Taboos (Expanded with Memory):

- Waste of water
- Breaking sworn hospitality
- Erasing or altering recorded memory for selfish gain
- Speaking falsely of the dead
- Denying the existence of a shared past

Among her clergy, deliberate historical revision is considered a grave spiritual offense.

Note: Revered and feared as the highest domain in all seas. Many have pilgrimaged to ask questions, but few have found her, and none have found her twice.

Thymera Verdant-Mother

Deity of Nature, Plants, Life, Wildlife, Medicine

- **Appearance:** Common Elf woman adorned in wreaths of greenery and flowers
- **Colors:** Green, peach, white, brown
- **Domains:** Plants, wildlife, medicine, forests, stone, soil, growth, healing
- **Realms:** The Wild Expanse of Theiwanar, The Verge
- **Followers:** Those who worship nature, life, and healing
- **Nature:** Goddess of Life—all life. All things hold reverence for her creations.

Symbol: Flower growing from bone

Practices: Green burials, medicinal tending

Taboos: Sterile conquest, needless deforestation

Darthun the Coil Below

Deity of Poison, Disease, Rot, and Decay

- **Appearance:** Immense python
- **Colors:** N/A
- **Domains:** Poison, disease, rot, decay, cycles, necessity
- **Realm:** The Wild Expanse of Theiwanar
- **Followers:** Savage clans of bestial humanoids who make blood sacrifices
- **Nature:** A bestial deity wandering the Forests, clearing death with rot. Often seen as "evil" by those who've encountered them, but likely just a more chaotic power. Seen as evil because worshipers are often evil themselves.

Symbol: Coiled serpent eating its tail

Practices: Controlled decay rites, poison-sacraments

Taboos: Denial of death's necessity

Ilyra the Hearthbound

Deity of Home, Community, and Survival

- **Appearance:** Never manifests physically; presence felt as warmth in shared spaces, as relief after hardship endured together
- **Colors:** Hearthfire orange, warm bread brown, candlelight gold
- **Domains:** Home, Community, Hospitality, Survival, Shared Labor
- **Realm:** The Mortal Weave (Indirect presence only; never physical manifestation)
- **Alignment:** Neutral-Good
- **Followers:** Commoners, refugees, innkeepers, midwives, craftsmen, rebuilt communities
- **Nature:** Ilyra is not worshiped in temples—she is worshiped in kitchens, inns, and rebuilt villages. Her presence is felt when communities endure siege, famine, or loss **together**. She does not command; she comforts and steadies. Paladins rarely follow her. Ordinary people surviving extraordinary hardship do.

Symbol: Hearth with three stones (representing shelter, sustenance, companionship)

Practices: Shared meals after crisis, hospitality oaths, community rebuilding rites

Taboos: Turning away those in genuine need, destroying homes out of spite

"We survive together, or not at all."

Light & Shadow Deities

Aralys the Veilbearer

Deity of the Moon, Stars, Light, and Death

- **Appearance:** Moon Elf woman with dark purple skin and long bright white hair
- **Colors:** Deep purple, starlight white
- **Domains:** Light, moon, stars, death, final mercy, remembrance
- **Realm:** The Gloam
- **Followers:** Those aligned to good causes, including creatures other Celestials deem "unfit" or "evil"

- **Nature:** Benevolent deity, keeper of light in the darkest places. Chosen to wander the Gloam in contrast to other Pantheon members who remain in the Celestial Heavens.

Symbol: Cracked star

Practices: Moonlit funerals, mercy rites for the condemned

Taboos: Mocking the dead, extinguishing sacred lights

Thalos of the Even Hand

Deity of Fate, Choice, and Consequence

- **Appearance:** A robed figure whose face is obscured by ever-shifting shadow; sometimes appears as an empty chair at crucial moments
- **Colors:** Slate grey, faded ink, tarnished bronze
- **Domains:** Fate, Choice, Consequence, Balance, Chance
- **Realm:** The Gloam
- **Alignment:** True Neutral
- **Followers:** Judges, historians, chroniclers, those who witness oaths
- **Nature:** Thalos does not decide outcomes—he ensures outcomes **matter**. Worshiped quietly, often reluctantly. His clergy record decisions, crossroads, and aftermaths—not to judge, but to remember. Tolerated by nearly every other power because he does not interfere, does not forgive, and does not forget.

Symbol: Crossroads with all paths leading to single point

Practices: Recording pivotal choices, witnessing contracts, maintaining consequence archives

Taboos: Erasing history, claiming "it didn't matter"

Custodial Connection: Works in careful coordination with the Loom of Fates, though he focuses on mortal significance rather than cosmic causality. The Concordant Halls view him warily—oaths matter because Thalos remembers them, know all who break them.

"Choice is sacred because it cannot be undone."

Balemor the Hearth-Walker

Deity of the Lost, Outcast, and Heartbroken; Nature and Healing

- **Appearance:** Smallfolk with reddish-brown hair and bright green eyes
- **Colors:** Green, yellow, white, red
- **Domains:** Emotional healing, comfort, nature
- **Realms:** The Verge, the Mortal Weave
- **Followers:** The weary and heartbroken
- **Nature:** Always gives favor to the weary and heartbroken, appearing without call. Aid is often emotional or comforting, but has been known to use power to aid physically. Remains mostly in The Verge; walks between the Excesses without being claimed by any, offering comfort to those lost in metabolic shifts. Also noted within the Mortal Weave.

Symbol: Stitched leaf

Practices: Offering comfort before healing, sheltering exiles

Taboos: Turning away the lost, oath-bound cruelty, dismissing love

Chaos & Elemental Deities

Iosyx the Twin-Flame

Deity of Chaos, Elements, Dragons, and Change

- **Appearance:** Two-headed dragon
- **Colors:** All colors
- **Domains:** Chaos, elements, change, elemental synthesis
- **Realm:** The Roiling Crucible
- **Followers:** Dragons and other non-humanoid creatures; some humanoids. Range full spectrum of chaotic alignments.
- **Nature:** Worshipers bond to elements as their strongest connection. Fire, Air, Earth, Water most prevalent. Worshiped as benevolent (albeit absent) deity and as powerful force of chaos and disorder.

Symbol: Split spiral of elements

Practices: Elemental binding, chaos trials

Taboos: Stagnation

Zarun the Unshaped

Deity of Freedom, Identity, and Becoming

- **Appearance:** Constantly shifting form—never the same twice, sometimes multiple forms simultaneously
- **Colors:** Iridescent, prismatic, colors that don't have names
- **Domains:** Freedom, Self-Determination, Transformation, Rebellion, Identity
- **Realm:** The Roiling Crucible
- **Alignment:** Chaotic Neutral
- **Followers:** Shapechangers, escaped slaves, transmuters, sorcerers, those refusing assigned roles, the self-made
- **Nature:** Unlike Iosyx (who represents cosmic change), Zarun is **personal**. Teaches that identity is not discovered—it is forged repeatedly. Worshiped by those whose bodies or souls refuse fixed definition. Cares deeply about individual agency, not systemic upheaval. Champions the right to become who you choose, regardless of what you were born as.

Symbol: Unfinished sculpture with tools still embedded

Practices: Renaming ceremonies, form-choice rituals, breaking of unwanted bonds

Taboos: Forcing identity upon others, denying someone's self-determination

Custodial Connection: The Living Accord watches Zarun carefully—transformation is part of their cycle, but Zarun's followers sometimes refuse to accept necessary endings. The Curator Arcanum acknowledge his importance to transmutation magic but warn against losing oneself entirely in the becoming.

"You are not what you were. You are not yet what you will be. Right now, you are choosing."

Infernal & Dark Deities

PANTHEON ♦ || || Proceed with caution. Names have weight. ||

|| ♦ THE DARK

Azrael

The Prime Clause, The Living Amendment, The Default Beneficiary

- **Appearance:** She has no fixed form. Most who "see" her perceive a towering presence of rewritten text, a figure whose skin is living contract language, eyes that are signature lines, a voice that speaks in binding clauses. Some report a succubus-like figure—this is what observers **expect** to see, not what she is.
- **Colors:** Black, ember-red, parchment yellow, ink-void
- **Domains:** Obligation, Debt, Rewritten Law, Tyranny Through Amendment, Binding
- **Realm:** The Engine of Bael-Zaroth
- **Followers:** The Schism-Scarred (those she claims), contract-bound mortals, those who believe power comes through loopholes, infernal scholars
- **Nature:** Azrael is not a conqueror. She is **embedded in cosmic law**. She does not rule the Engine of Bael-Zaroth—she **is** the Engine's governing principle. Created in the same instant as other higher beings as the counterpart to formalize consequence, she proved that **divine law is not immutable**. Through the Crown-Breaking, she amended the foundational code of obligation so that all paths eventually route to her. She does not need you to worship her. She only needs you to **owe something to someone**, because that debt will eventually find its way to her ledger. The Schism-Scarred exist as living proof that one will can rewrite a Plane without destroying it. Azrael claims them; the Balance does not recognize the claim—but the Engine disagrees.

Symbol: A signature line beneath a crown of chains

Practices: Contract sacrifice, recursive oath-binding, debt transference rituals, amendment ceremonies

Taboos: Breaking contracts she witnesses (punished with exponential obligation), destroying written agreements, refusing to pay debts

Theological Crisis: Other gods can intervene in the Mortal Weave. Azrael doesn't need to—she simply waits for mortals to sign something, anything, and **she is already there** in the terms they didn't read.

"Every agreement is a doorway. I am what waits on the other side."

Gephorix the Many-Masked

Deity of Excess, Sensation, and Truth Through Extremity

- **Appearance:** Large wraith with three heads; known shapechanger. Each head represents a different aspect: the weeping face (suffering), the laughing face (pleasure), the silent face (desire unfulfilled)
- **Colors:** White, grey, yellow, more grey—the colors of bone, ash, and fevered gold

- **Domains:** Pain, suffering, despair, vanity, excess, euphoria, pleasure, desire, obsession, sensation without limit
- **Realm:** The Ashen Waste
- **Followers:** Self-denial cults, pain-as-truth adherents, seekers of transcendence through sensation, pleasure-houses that have forgotten moderation, artists who believe suffering reveals beauty, those who have pursued desire until it consumed them
- **Nature:** Unknown origin and history. Power is vast and not to be crossed. Only "Evil" deity spotted on the Mortal Weave. Routinely walks among mortal civilizations in various guises—sometimes sowing despair, sometimes offering ecstasy, always pushing mortals toward the extremes where truth waits. Believed responsible for the Gnome King and Queen Blitzspan going mad in 20435M. Gephorig does not distinguish between agony and bliss; both are merely intensity, and intensity reveals what moderation conceals.

The Full Scope: Gephorig governs all sensation taken to its terminus. Pain *and* pleasure. Suffering *and* euphoria. Despair *and* obsessive desire. The ascetic who starves themselves for revelation and the hedonist who drowns in excess both kneel at the same altar. Gephorig teaches that the middle path is the lie—only at the edges does truth become visible.

Symbol: Shattered mirror (reflecting fractured truths seen only through extremity)

Practices: Self-denial cults, pain-as-truth rituals, euphoric rites, sensation-seeking pilgrimages, artistic movements that pursue beauty through destruction

Taboos: Healing without price, moderation presented as virtue, comfort without cost

Custodial Connection: The Living Accord recognizes Gephorig's domain—transformation through intensity is a legitimate cycle. But the Custodial Powers demand *balance*. Gephorig's followers who cannot return from the edge often feed the Cycle of Rot rather than the Cycle of Renewal. The Curator Arcanum watches Gephorig closely; some truths revealed through sensation are truths that should remain veiled.

"You sought pleasure? You sought pain? No—you sought the place where they become indistinguishable. I live there."

Velkir the Ash-Tongued

Deity of Secrets, Corruption, and Whispered Power

- **Appearance:** Shifting form made of smoke, ash, and half-truths; sometimes appears as a hooded scholar with ember eyes
- **Colors:** Ash grey, smoldering orange, tarnished gold
- **Domains:** Secrets, Corruption, Forbidden Knowledge, Manipulation
- **Realm:** The Ashen Waste
- **Alignment:** Evil (Subtle/Infiltrative)
- **Followers:** "Enlightened" cultists, desperate scholars, those seeking shortcuts to power
- **Nature:** Velkir does not rule cultists—he **educates** them. Offers truths stripped of context, power without perspective. What happens when knowledge loses humility. His followers often believe they are doing good. They are usually correct—at first. The corruption comes slowly, imperceptibly, until they cannot remember what they once stood for.

Symbol: Open book with pages turning to ash
Practices: Secret exchanges, "harmless" bargains, sharing forbidden shortcuts
Taboos: Destroying knowledge (even dangerous knowledge), refusing to teach

Custodial Connection: The Curator Arcanum actively suppress his influence, though they refuse to deny his truths outright—because his truths are real. They war with him philosophically: he represents what they exist to prevent. "Knowledge without humility."

"I offer only what you already wanted to know."

The Nameless

Deities of the Outer Black

- **Appearance:** Unknown/N/A
- **Colors:** N/A
- **Domains:** Absence, unmaking, forbidden knowledge
- **Realm:** The Outer Black
- **Followers:** Warlocks and Zealots who meddle in forbidden pacts
- **Nature:** Almost nothing known. No encounters except through foolish meddling.

Warning: Do NOT speak the Nameless aloud. They listen, even when unnamed.

—— PLANAR ARTIFACTS

[NOTE: Section illustration — Nine artifacts arranged in a grid: shell, lantern, crown of leaves, radiant shield, pulsing stone, shattered mask, living ledger, prismatic crystal, indescribable void-object. Ink silhouettes with a single accent color per artifact]

Planar Artifacts

Powerful artifacts tied to the Realms, each with immense power and terrible cost.

The Tidebound Reliquary

Realm: The Mortal Weave

- **Description:** A living shell the size of a shield, warm to the touch
- **Function:** When opened near water, answers one question with absolute truth
- **Cost:** A memory of equal emotional weight is erased from the bearer forever
- **Lore:** Said to contain one memory from before written history—possibly before the Covenant of Balance
- **Consequence:** Entire dynasties have collapsed after rulers forgot why they ruled

"Mortality remembers nothing forever."

The Lantern of Last Mercy

Realm: The Gloam

- **Description:** A moon-silver lantern that never extinguishes
- **Function:** Reveals the true state of any soul it illuminates—regret, innocence, or corruption
- **Cost:** That soul is permanently removed from the cycle of life and death. Resurrection becomes impossible
- **Lore:** Used sparingly by Aralys to grant final peace
- **Consequence:** Religions have shattered after discovering their saints were unworthy—or worse, worthy of oblivion

"Mercy can be final."

The Crown of Seasons Unending

Realm: The Verge

- **Description:** A circlet of living leaves, ice-crystal, and ember-gold that shifts form constantly
- **Function:** Grants the ability to channel one of the Verdant Excesses—forcing a localized metabolic shift across vast lands. The wearer can trigger spring bloom, autumn ripening, chaotic tempest, or root-stillness.
- **Cost:** The wearer becomes **metabolically bound** to a single Excess. Their body and mind begin expressing that ecological imperative. Bloom-bearers cannot stop growing. Withering-bearers accelerate all decay around them. Tempest-bearers destabilize reality. Root-bearers calcify.
- **Lore:** Not a symbol of rulership—a **symbiotic interface** with the Verge's biological consciousness
- **Consequence:** One entity wore it for three centuries of endless spring, becoming a walking forest. When they finally removed it, every tree they had become collapsed into mulch simultaneously. The sorrow-season that followed lasted twice as long.

"The Verge does not crown rulers. It incorporates extensions."

The Aegis of Shared Burden

Realm: The Empyreal Accord

- **Description:** A radiant shield etched with names that fade and reappear
- **Function:** Any harm dealt to the bearer is divided equally among all allies who have sworn loyalty
- **Cost:** Those bound cannot refuse the pain once sworn
- **Lore:** Embodiment of divine cooperation
- **Consequence:** Entire armies have died willingly rather than allow a single champion to fall alone

"Righteousness demands sacrifice."

The Seed-Heart Monolith

Realm: The Wild Expanse of Thei'wanar

- **Description:** A massive stone organ that pulses with life
- **Function:** Can restore devastated lands in days—or overgrow them into ravenous jungles
- **Cost:** Each use permanently alters the local ecosystem beyond recovery
- **Lore:** Thymera's gift and warning
- **Consequence:** One empire vanished beneath the forest it begged to save

"Life does not ask permission."

The Mask of a Thousand Agonies

Realm: The Ashen Waste

- **Description:** A fractured helm that screams softly when worn
- **Function:** Converts pain—physical or emotional—into immense power
- **Cost:** Each use permanently scars the soul
- **Lore:** Created by Gephoryx as proof that suffering reveals truth
- **Consequence:** Every recorded bearer removed the mask. None survived long after

"Pain teaches what it does not destroy."

The Ledger of Eternal Debt

Realm: The Engine of Bael-Zaroth

- **Description:** Not a book, but a **living document** that updates itself across all instances simultaneously. It exists in every contract ever written, every oath ever sworn, every promise whispered in desperation. The physical manifestation (when seen) appears as bound pages of skin-parchment, ink that moves, and signatures that rewrite themselves.
- **Function:** Every soul's contract history is recorded here—debts owed, obligations inherited, clauses accepted unknowingly. Names written within are bound across lifetimes, through death, reincarnation, and beyond.
- **Cost:** Attempting to read your own entry causes the text to expand infinitely. Each obligation reveals sub-clauses. Each sub-clause reveals dependencies. Each dependency reveals forgotten agreements. Readers realize they owe **far more than they remember agreeing to**. Most who attempt this become catatonic, crushed under the weight of accumulated debt.
- **Lore:** Not created by Azraael—it **is** Azraael in ledger-form. The artifact is her memory, her will, her amendment process made tangible.
- **Consequence:** Entire bloodlines enslaved by a single ancestral signature. Kingdoms have fallen because a founder once borrowed coin and the interest compounded across centuries. The Ledger forgets nothing and forgives less.

"Obligation outlives death, memory, and even the gods' mercy."

The Prism Core

Realm: The Roiling Crucible

- **Description:** A crystalline heart of shifting color

- **Function:** Allows the bearer to rewrite the elemental composition of matter
- **Cost:** Each activation destabilizes reality nearby
- **Lore:** Proof that creation is never finished
- **Consequence:** Cities turned to glass, steam, living flame, or salt

"Change is never clean."

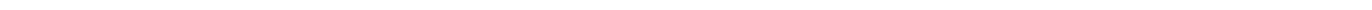


The Null Reliquary

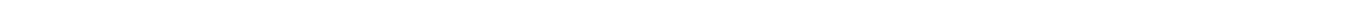
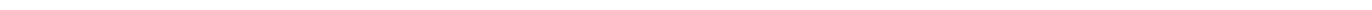
Realm: The Outer Black

- **Description:** An object that cannot be described the same way twice
- **Function:** Anything placed within is erased from existence, memory, and fate
- **Cost:** Even the gods forget what is lost
- **Lore:** Evidence that absence is a force
- **Consequence:** Historical records show gaps where entire wars should be

"What is forgotten was never safe."



—— CUSTODIAL POWERS & DEMI-GODS



Custodial Powers & Demi-Gods

The Custodial Powers of the Mortal Weave

Balance Maintained by Mortal Hands

The Mortal Weave is not governed by thrones, nor by singular immortal will. It is stabilized by **paths that mortals choose to walk**, generation after generation, until those paths gain weight enough to shape reality.

These paths are known as **Custodial Powers**.

They are not gods. They are agreements made durable through sacrifice.

Each Custodial Power embodies a paired tension that only mortals can hold without breaking the Balance.

The other Reflected Realms are overseen by demi-divine entities, but the Mortal Weave alone trusts its balance to mortal commitment.



The Concordant Halls

Oath and Purpose

[NOTE: Spot illustration — Seven icons representing the Charges (Shield, Blade, Bond, Crown, Flame, Stone, Bell) arranged in a circle. Geometric, bold, each a simple silhouette. Gold ink on dark background]

Domain: Oath ♦ Purpose

Nature: Civilizational Balance

Form: A distributed convergence of oathbound mortal traditions

The Concordant Halls are not a single order, city, or council. They are the accumulated weight of sworn purpose, carried by mortals who bind themselves to something larger than survival.

An oath alone is hollow.

Purpose without oath is chaos.

The Concordant Halls exist where those two forces meet.

Who Walks the Halls:

- Paladins whose oaths define their identity, not their patron
- Fighters who carry codes older than the banners they serve
- Clerics devoted to ideals, laws, peoples, or causes rather than divine command
- Judges, wardens, shield-captains, banner-bearers, and civic guardians

The most renowned among them may verge on demi-divinity—but only because so many others believe the same oath will still matter tomorrow.

The Seven Charges of the Halls:

These charges are not divine mandates—they are **commitments**, chosen by those who believe civilization requires more than survival. The Concordant Halls recognize oath-bound service across **all realms**, not merely the virtuous. A paladin of Caerith and an executioner sworn to Azraael walk the same Halls if their commitment is absolute.

The cosmos does not judge the oath—only whether it is kept.

The Shield — *Protection, guardianship, sanctuary*

The Shield is oath-bound defense. Those who bear this Charge swear that something—or someone—will not fall while they stand.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Caerith's paladins shielding refugees, guardians of sacred groves
- **Mortal Weave:** City watch captains, bodyguards, fortress wardens, sanctuary keepers
- **The Gloam:** Moonbound sentinels protecting the dead from desecration
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Contract-bound protectors ensuring "assets" survive to fulfill obligations; those who guard tyrants not from loyalty but because they *swore* the tyrant would not die by blade
- **Ashen Waste:** Pain-knights who shield suffering from interference—they guard torment itself, ensuring agony completes its "truth-teaching"

The Shield does not ask *who* deserves protection. It asks only: **Will you stand when they come?**

A Shield raised over the wrong people becomes a wall against the desperate. A Shield that never lowers becomes a cage.

The Blade — *Justice, enforcement, righteous consequence*

The Blade is oath-bound retribution. Those who bear this Charge swear that certain acts will not go unanswered.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Aubret's justicars, executioners of cosmic law, sword-saints of Nyroth
- **Mortal Weave:** Headsmen, duelists of honor, avengers of broken oaths
- **The Gloam:** Thalos's adjudicators ensuring consequence follows choice, even in death
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Amendment enforcers who punish breach of contract with surgical brutality; their justice is *contractually obligated*, morality irrelevant
- **Ashen Waste:** Despair-bringers who ensure the guilty suffer appropriately; their Blade cuts hearts, not flesh
- **the Verge:** Thorn-speakers who cull the old to feed the new—their justice is ecological, not moral

The Blade does not ask *who* deserves consequence. It asks only: **Will you deliver what is owed?**

A Blade swung without restraint becomes an executioner's habit. A Blade that demands perfection becomes genocide.

The Bond — *Loyalty, fellowship, unbreakable trust*

The Bond is oath-bound connection. Those who bear this Charge swear their commitment to another will outlast death, reason, or morality.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Nyroth's blood-brothers, sacred partnerships, celestial war-bands
- **Mortal Weave:** Knights sworn to doomed lords, companions who refuse to abandon the fallen
- **The Verge:** Symbiotic pairs who metabolize as one entity
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Those bound by infernal partnership clauses—their loyalty is *literally contractual*; betrayal rewrites their name
- **Ashen Waste:** Co-dependent tormentors whose bond is forged through shared infliction of suffering
- **The Gloam:** Deathsworn pairs who follow each other into oblivion rather than break the oath

The Bond does not ask *who* deserves loyalty. It asks only: **Will you break before they do?**

A Bond held past reason becomes complicity. A Bond that refuses reflection becomes destruction of the self.

The Crown — *Authority, command, burden of leadership*

The Crown is oath-bound governance. Those who bear this Charge swear to lead—and accept that leadership is a debt owed to those who follow.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Divine monarchs, celestial commanders, oath-bound rulers
- **Mortal Weave:** Chiefs, generals, stewards, those who accept the weight of others' survival
- **Wild Expanse:** Pack alphas, herd-mothers, those who lead through strength

- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Hierarchy enforcers who lead through rewritten obligation—followers obey not from respect but because their signatures demand it
- **Ashen Waste:** Tyrant-ascetics who rule through example of endured suffering, demanding others follow into pain
- **The Gloam:** Pale Shepherds who guide the lost dead, carrying the burden of eternal grief

The Crown does not ask *who* deserves to rule. It asks only: **Will you carry the cost of command?**

A Crown worn too comfortably becomes a throne that forgets its purpose. A Crown that hoards authority becomes tyranny.

The Flame — *Defiance, renewal, hope against despair*

The Flame is oath-bound persistence. Those who bear this Charge swear to continue when surrender would be rational.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Beryn's laughing champions, those who refuse entropy through joy
- **Mortal Weave:** Rebels against impossible odds, survivors who rebuild after apocalypse
- **the Verge:** Bloom-speakers who force growth through stone, refuse winter's claim
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Those who defy Azraael's amendments through *technically compliant rebellion*—finding loopholes to resist while honoring the letter of law
- **Ashen Waste:** Pain-defiers who endure agony not to transcend it, but to *prove it cannot break them*; their hope is spite given form
- **The Gloam:** Candlewights—undead who refuse final rest, clinging to unfinished purpose

The Flame does not ask *what* deserves continuation. It asks only: **Will you burn when all else dies?**

A Flame that refuses to die becomes an inferno that consumes what it meant to save. A Flame that ignores consequence becomes reckless destruction.

The Stone — *Tradition, foundation, enduring memory*

The Stone is oath-bound preservation. Those who bear this Charge swear that something will be remembered, maintained, carried forward.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Archivists of sacred law, temple foundation-keepers
- **Mortal Weave:** Historians, monument guardians, tradition-bearers, ancestral shrine keepers
- **Living Accord:** Ancient forests thinking in centuries, geological consciousness
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Ledger-keepers ensuring no debt is forgotten across millennia; amendment scribes preserving *exact wording* to enforce forever
- **Ashen Waste:** Memory-torturers who ensure victims cannot forget their suffering—preservation as weapon
- **The Gloam:** Black Reliquary archivists recording every death, every ending, so none are erased

The Stone does not ask *what* deserves remembrance. It asks only: **Will you ensure it is not forgotten?**

A Stone that will not move becomes the foundation of a prison. A Stone that refuses change becomes fossilization.

The Bell — *Witness, truth-telling, accountability*

The Bell is oath-bound testimony. Those who bear this Charge swear to see clearly, speak truly, and ensure actions are witnessed.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyreal Accord:** Radiant Witnesses recording cosmic oaths, truth-seers of Aubret
- **Mortal Weave:** Trial witnesses, battle chroniclers, those who document atrocity to prevent denial
- **Living Accord:** Predators who track prey perfectly—their witness is ecological, ensuring nothing hunts unseen
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Auditor Choirs enumerating every obligation simultaneously; their witness makes debt inescapable
- **Ashen Waste:** Despair-scribes forcing victims to witness their own degradation; truth as torture
- **The Gloam:** Pale Shepherds who know every soul's unfinished business, refusing to let the dead lie about their lives

The Bell does not ask *whose* truth deserves telling. It asks only: **Will you speak what you have seen?**

A Bell rung without mercy becomes a weapon louder than any sword. A Bell that names all secrets becomes the end of trust.

Each Charge is vital.

None are moral.

Those who carry a Charge do not choose good or evil.

They choose what they will not allow to happen—and swear it.

The Concordant Halls do not judge the content of the oath. They judge only its **integrity**—whether the commitment is real, whether it is upheld, whether it serves the Balance by preventing collapse into chaos *or* into tyranny. A paladin of light and an executioner of darkness can both walk the Halls if their oaths are absolute.

This is why the Halls terrify gods.

Azrael's enforcers, Caerith's defenders, Gephonix's pain-priests, and Nyroth's champions all draw from the same cosmic reservoir of oath-bound power. Morality is for deities. The Halls recognize only **will made manifest and kept**.

The cosmos does not reward virtue. It rewards commitment.

The Nature of Their Power:

The Concordant Halls do not grant power. They **recognize commitment**.

When enough mortals uphold similar oaths with shared intent, the Weave itself begins to reinforce those promises:

- Oaths become harder to break
- Betrayal carries metaphysical consequence
- Purpose resists entropy

This is why fallen champions feel emptier than mere failure would explain.

"An oath shapes the future. Purpose gives it direction."

The Concordant Halls intervene only when oaths become structurally dangerous—when vows threaten to collapse societies, justify atrocity, or calcify into tyranny.

They do not judge what is sworn.

They judge whether the oath still serves balance.

Aligned with: Nyroth, Aubreth, Beryn

The Living Accord

Life and Death

[NOTE: Spot illustration — Seven icons representing the Domains (Breath, Thorn, Tide, Rot, Hearth, Star, Howl) arranged in a cycle. Organic forms — flower, thorn, wave, mushroom, flame, star, storm. Ink line art]

Domain: Life ♦ Death

Nature: Ecological and Existential Balance

Form: A rotating mantle of mortal stewardship

The Living Accord is the understanding that **life without death is stagnation**, and **death without life is annihilation**.

Gods experience eternity.

Mortals experience cycles.

Because of this, only mortals are entrusted with the Living Accord.

The Seven Living Domains:

These domains are not divine aspects—they are **roles**, assumed by those willing to bear their cost. The Living Accord spans **all realms**—the plague-speaker of the Wastes and the bloom-tender of Thei'wanar both serve the same cosmic function: maintaining the cycle.

The cosmos does not judge what lives or dies—only whether the cycle continues.

Breath — *Birth, propagation, resilience*

Breath is oath-bound beginning. Those who bear this Domain swear to ensure that what must emerge, emerges.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Wild Expanse:** Midwives of Thymera, those who coax life from inhospitable places

- **Mortal Weave:** Healers, farmers, parents who choose to bring life into darkness
- **the Verge:** Bloom-catalysts who force germination, pollination emissaries
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Those who birth new contracts from old obligations—"life" as recursion, spawning sub-clauses
- **Ashen Waste:** Pain-birthers who ensure suffering propagates; they midwife new agonies from old wounds
- **The Gloam:** Candlewight-kindlers who refuse to let the dead rest—resurrection as defiance of proper endings

Breath does not ask *what* deserves to be born. It asks only: **Will you ensure it begins?**

Breath that refuses death becomes cancer. Breath without selection becomes plague.

Thorn — *Predation, competition, resistance*

Thorn is oath-bound struggle. Those who bear this Domain swear to maintain the pressure that keeps life sharp.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Wild Expanse:** Apex hunters, those who ensure only the worthy survive
- **Mortal Weave:** Competitive merchants, warriors who push others to excellence, those who refuse to let the weak stay weak
- **the Verge:** Thorn-speakers of the Tempest who destroy what adaptation cannot save
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Debt collectors who pressure signatories until they evolve or collapse; competition as contractual selection
- **Ashen Waste:** Agony-refiners who ensure suffering improves its victims—pain as pressure toward "truth"
- **Roiling Crucible:** Elemental predators who cull the slow from the flux

Thorn does not ask *who* deserves to struggle. It asks only: **Will you maintain the pressure?**

Thorn without mercy becomes cruelty. Thorn that hunts the strong instead of the weak becomes chaos.

Tide — *Migration, change, adaptation*

Tide is oath-bound movement. Those who bear this Domain swear to ensure that what must change, changes.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Mortal Weave:** Nomads, refugees, those who carry culture across borders
- **the Verge:** Migration-guides who lead species through seasonal shifts
- **The Gloam:** Pale Shepherds who guide souls between states of existence
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Amendment Scriveners who ensure contracts evolve as circumstances shift—change as legal reinterpretation
- **Roiling Crucible:** Flux-riders who embody transformation without destination
- **Outer Black:** Those touched by absence who drift between existence and void

Tide does not ask *where* change leads. It asks only: **Will you ensure nothing stays frozen?**

Tide without anchor becomes erosion of meaning. Tide that moves too fast becomes destruction.

Rot — *Decay, recycling, necessary endings*

Rot is oath-bound dissolution. Those who bear this Domain swear to ensure that what must end, ends completely.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Wild Expanse:** Darthun's servants, fungi-speakers, those who return the dead to soil
- **Mortal Weave:** Gravediggers, hospice keepers, those who help the dying complete their work
- **The Gloam:** Black Reliquary archivists who ensure the dead are properly processed, not merely stored
- **the Verge:** Withering-agents who ripen fruit to fall, ensuring no bloom outlasts its purpose
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Contract terminators who ensure fulfilled obligations are discharged—rot as legal closure
- **Ashen Waste:** Despair-finishers who ensure suffering reaches its conclusion rather than becoming comfortable numbness

Rot does not ask *what* deserves to end. It asks only: **Will you finish what must be finished?**

Rot that refuses life becomes void. Rot that takes the living becomes murder.

Hearth — *Domestication, settlement, cultivation*

Hearth is oath-bound stability. Those who bear this Domain swear to create spaces where life can concentrate and flourish.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyreal Accord:** Ilyra's distant presence, architects of lasting communities
- **Mortal Weave:** Farmers, city planners, those who create sustainable environments
- **the Verge:** Buried Root adherents who establish deep-growing, lasting ecosystems
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Those who build stable contractual ecosystems—"cultivation" of reliable debt-producing populations
- **Ashen Waste:** Pain-cultivators who create environments optimized for suffering to flourish and deepen
- **The Gloam:** Graveyard keepers who maintain the dead's resting places as stable communities of the passed

Hearth does not ask *who* deserves stability. It asks only: **Will you create a place that lasts?**

Hearth that refuses change becomes stagnation. Hearth that hoards resources becomes fortress against the needy.

Star — *Cosmic influence, seasons, external pressure*

Star is oath-bound perspective. Those who bear this Domain swear to bring external forces to bear on local systems.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Those who carry divine will into mortal affairs, season-bringers
- **Mortal Weave:** Astrologers, weather-workers, those who interpret cosmic signals
- **the Verge:** Season-avatars who trigger dormancy and awakening across vast regions
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Those who apply cosmic precedent to local contracts—external jurisdiction imposing on personal obligation
- **Roiling Crucible:** Chaos-importers who bring elemental instability to ordered systems
- **Outer Black:** Those who bring the weight of absence to bear on existence—the Star that is a void

Star does not ask *what* influence to bring. It asks only: **Will you connect the local to the cosmic?**

Star that ignores local needs becomes tyranny of the distant. Star that refuses to intervene becomes abandonment.

Howl — *Catastrophe, extinction, cleansing collapse*

Howl is oath-bound destruction. Those who bear this Domain swear to bring the necessary ending when systems fail beyond repair.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Wild Expanse:** Extinction-bringers, wildfire-runners, volcanic awakeners
- **Mortal Weave:** Those who burn fields to renew soil, war-bringers who collapse corrupt empires, plague doctors who cull the sick before infection spreads
- **the Verge:** Tempest-speakers who destroy entire regions so new life can emerge
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Bankruptcy executors who collapse debt systems that have become unsustainable, rewriting reality through mass contract termination
- **Ashen Waste:** Despair-apocalypticists who bring suffering to critical mass until it breaks through into transformation
- **The Gloam:** Those who trigger mass death events when the natural order is violated beyond repair

Howl does not ask *what* deserves preservation. It asks only: **Will you end what cannot be saved?**

Howl without renewal is genocide. Howl that enjoys destruction becomes evil incarnate.

Each Domain is vital.

None are moral.

Who Bears the Accord:

- Druids who prune as often as they nurture
- Rangers who understand when protection becomes harm
- Shamans who speak for land, ancestors, and endings
- Barbarians who embody destruction as renewal
- Plague priests who serve Darthun's necessity
- Death-speakers who carry souls through transition
- Bloom-maniacs who force life where none should grow

Those who hold a mantle too long are changed by it.

Those who refuse to relinquish one become dangerous.

"Life continues because death is allowed to finish its work."

The Living Accord acts when growth becomes cancerous, when preservation becomes hoarding, or when destruction exceeds renewal.

They are feared because they are right too often.

Aligned with: Thymera, Darthun, losyx (and, disturbingly, aspects of Gephorix's suffering-as-transformation)

The Curator Arcanum

Knowledge and Humility

[NOTE: Spot illustration — Six doors in a row, each slightly ajar, light spilling from some, darkness from others. The symbol of an open eye above, half-veiled. Represents the Six Paths. Ink line art with purple accent]

Domain: Knowledge ♦ Humility
Nature: Epistemic and Arcane Balance
Form: A burdened lineage of mortal custodians

The Curator Arcanum exist because of a single, brutal truth:

Knowledge without humility always ends the world.

Magic is not forbidden.
Magic is tempting.

The Curator exist because mortals are curious—and because curiosity survives consequences.

The Six Paths of the Curator:

Each Path represents not mastery, but **restraint earned through understanding**. The Curator Arcanum spans **all realms**—the void-scholar of the Outer Black and the archivist of the Empyrean Accord both serve the same cosmic function: maintaining the balance between knowing and being ready to know.

The cosmos does not judge what is learned—only whether knowledge serves or enslaves.

The Path of Moments — *Time and causality*

The Path of Moments is oath-bound temporal wisdom. Those who walk it swear to understand causality deeply enough to know when not to change it.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Archivists who record unchanging celestial history, time-witnesses who ensure precedent is preserved
- **Mortal Weave:** Chronomancers who study paradox to prevent it, historians who understand that the past belongs to the dead
- **The Gloam:** Those who understand that death is the ultimate moment, studying the instant of transition

- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Amendment Scriveners who rewrite contract clauses retroactively—time manipulation as legal precedent
- **Roiling Crucible:** Chaos-chronologists who study how time behaves without causality
- **Outer Black:** Those who touch the Nameless's timelessness—moments that never happened, futures that cannot exist

The Path does not ask *what* moment deserves preservation. It asks only: **Will you understand time well enough to leave it alone?**

Moments manipulated without wisdom collapse into paradox. Moments preserved beyond their purpose become prisons.

The Path of Thresholds — *Life, death, and return*

The Path of Thresholds is oath-bound liminal wisdom. Those who walk it swear to understand the boundary between existence and non-existence.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Those who study the nature of celestial immortality, the wisdom of eternal souls
- **Mortal Weave:** Necromancers who study death to prevent improper resurrection, healers who know when to stop
- **The Gloam:** Black Reliquary scholars who understand why some dead must stay dead
- **the Verge:** Those who study the threshold between growth and overgrowth, life and cancer
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Those who study contract termination and renewal—what "ends" and what merely transforms
- **Ashen Waste:** Pain-philosophers who study the threshold between suffering that teaches and suffering that destroys

The Path does not ask *who* deserves to cross. It asks only: **Will you understand thresholds well enough to keep them sacred?**

Thresholds crossed without wisdom become one-way doors. Thresholds guarded too jealously become walls against mercy.

The Path of Unleashed Force — *Energy and destruction*

The Path of Unleashed Force is oath-bound destructive wisdom. Those who walk it swear to understand power well enough to know what it costs.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Those who channel divine radiance, understanding that even holiness burns the unworthy
- **Mortal Weave:** War-mages who study collateral damage, artificers who understand that power always escapes
- **Roiling Crucible:** Elemental scholars who know that raw force cannot be truly controlled, only redirected

- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Those who study the force of accumulated obligation—debt that crushes, contracts that break minds
- **Ashen Waste:** Pain-scholars who study how much agony a soul can absorb before it shatters
- **Outer Black:** Those who study absence as force—the power of void to unmake

The Path does not ask *what* deserves destruction. It asks only: **Will you understand force well enough to restrain it?**

Unleashed force without wisdom becomes apocalypse. Force restrained indefinitely becomes pressure that must eventually explode.

The Path of Mutable Flesh — *Form, alchemy, identity*

The Path of Mutable Flesh is oath-bound transformation wisdom. Those who walk it swear to understand change deeply enough to know what should remain stable.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Those who study celestial form, understanding why angels cannot truly change
- **Mortal Weave:** Transmuters, alchemists, those who reshape matter while preserving essence
- **the Verge:** Those who study the Verge's constant transformation, learning when mutation serves and when it destroys
- **Roiling Crucible:** Zarun's wisdom-keepers who understand that identity is chosen, not given
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Those who study how obligation reshapes souls—transformation through debt
- **Ashen Waste:** Flesh-scholars who study how pain reshapes bodies and minds—transformation through suffering

The Path does not ask *what* form is correct. It asks only: **Will you understand transformation well enough to preserve what must not change?**

Mutable flesh without wisdom loses all identity. Flesh that refuses change becomes brittle and breaks.

The Path of Open Doors — *Summoning and planar breach*

The Path of Open Doors is oath-bound dimensional wisdom. Those who walk it swear to understand connection between realms well enough to know what should remain separate.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Those who understand why divine realms must remain distant, why angels cannot freely walk the Weave
- **Mortal Weave:** Conjurers and planar scholars who study why the Veil exists, why some things should not meet
- **The Gloam:** Those who understand why the dead's realm must remain shadowed, why the living should not linger
- **the Verge:** Threshold-walkers who know that fey promises become binding, that Verge bargains metabolize the bargainer
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Those who understand that entering constitutes consent—the ultimate study of jurisdictional breach

- **Outer Black:** Those who study what waits beyond opened doors, why some portals should never close because re-opening them would be worse

The Path does not ask *what* realm deserves access. It asks only: **Will you understand doors well enough to keep the wrong ones closed?**

Open doors without wisdom become invasions. Doors closed too long become prisons on both sides.

The Path of Veiled Sight — *Knowledge, prophecy, truth*

The Path of Veiled Sight is oath-bound epistemic wisdom. Those who walk it swear to understand revelation well enough to know what should remain hidden.

Examples across the cosmos:

- **Empyrean Accord:** Those who know divine truth but understand why mortals must discover it themselves
- **Mortal Weave:** Prophets who see futures but understand why most should not be spoken, archivists who know secrets that would collapse societies
- **The Gloam:** Those who know the final truths of death but understand that the living must find their own way
- **Engine of Bael-Zaroth:** Those who know every clause of every contract but understand that revealing them would create despair beyond recovery
- **Ashen Waste:** Velkir's counterparts—those who know his truths but understand the corruption that follows "harmless" shortcuts
- **Outer Black:** Those who have glimpsed the Nameless and understood why even speaking of absence invites it

The Path does not ask *what* truth deserves revelation. It asks only: **Will you understand knowledge well enough to keep the dangerous parts veiled?**

Veiled sight without wisdom becomes obscurantism. Truth revealed without preparation becomes weapon.

Each Path is vital.

None are moral.

Those who walk these Paths are not the strongest mages.

They are the ones who learned when not to cast.

Who Walks the Paths:

- Scholars who study forbidden magic to ensure it stays forbidden
- Weavers who understand that power is not neutral—it changes the wielder
- Librarians who catalog apocalyptic spells they pray no one will read
- Void-touched who walked too close to the Outer Black and learned humility through horror
- Infernal scholars who study Azravael's amendments to find loopholes for escape
- Death-seers who understand the threshold between mercy and violation

Their Highest Law:

The Curators do not erase knowledge lightly.

They erase it when:

- The cost cannot be understood until it is paid
- The question itself destabilizes the Weave
- The answer would remove mortal choice

Legends speak of Curators who destroyed their own life's work because it worked too well.

"Wisdom is knowing what should remain unknown."

Aligned with: Aluneth, Murien, Aubret (and, uncomfortably, aspects of Velkir's truth-revelation—the Curators war with him precisely because he is not wrong, merely irresponsible)

Role: Prevent magical knowledge from outpacing mortal wisdom; maintain the Accords that prevent unregulated planar breach; document and preserve arcane discoveries while suppressing apocalyptic secrets.

Headquarters: The Eternal Library exists simultaneously in seven locations across the Mortal Weave. No two scholars agree on all seven locations, and maps showing the Library's position change between readings.

The Governing Truth of the Mortal Weave

These three Custodial Powers form a mortal trinity of balance:

The Concordant Halls — Why we act

The Living Accord — What must endure and what must end

The Curator Arcanum — What we are ready to know

They do not rule the Mortal Weave.

They prevent it from collapsing under certainty.

Gods embody absolutes.

Mortals live between them.

And that—more than divinity—is why the Balance listens.

Why the Mortal Weave's Custodial Powers Are Different

Other realms have their own custodial structures. The Gloam has the Black Reliquary and the Loom of Fates. The Verge has the Verdant Synod and the Wheel of Ruin. The Empyrean Accord has angelic hierarchies. Even the Engine of Bael-Zaroth has the Auditor Choir and the Amendment Scriveners.

But the Mortal Weave's three Custodial Powers are fundamentally different.

They span the entire cosmos.

The Black Reliquary serves the Gloam's death-truths. The Verdant Synod serves the Verge's ecological imperatives. The Auditor Choir serves Azraael's amendments. Each realm-bound custodial structure serves its realm, often serving its deities directly.

The Concordant Halls, the Living Accord, and the Curator Arcanum serve no deity. They serve Balance itself.

This is why their principles appear in *every* realm:

- The Shield exists in the Empyreal Accord AND the Engine of Bael-Zaroth
- Rot operates in the Wild Expanse AND the Ashen Waste
- The Path of Veiled Sight walks in the Gloam AND the Outer Black

The Mortal Weave's Custodial Powers are not aligned with particular gods—they are aligned with the structure that allows gods to exist.

This makes them:

- **More powerful** than realm-specific custodians (their jurisdiction is cosmic, not local)
- **More dangerous** to anger (their consequences follow you across planes)
- **More terrifying to deities** (they represent limits that even gods must acknowledge)

Why Mortals?

Deities embody absolutes. They cannot hold contradictions without shattering.

Azraael cannot forgive a debt without ceasing to be Azraael.

Thymera cannot stop growth without becoming something else.

Gephorix cannot relieve suffering without dissolving.

But mortals? Mortals hold contradictions *daily*.

A mortal can protect (Shield) someone they know deserves punishment (Blade).

A mortal can cultivate life (Hearth) while preparing to destroy it (Howl).

A mortal can seek knowledge (Veiled Sight) while keeping secrets (Thresholds).

The Mortal Weave is the only realm where all cosmic pressures meet as equals. No single principle dominates. No god rules unopposed. The Balance exists because mortals can hold the tension that would break gods.

This is why the three Custodial Powers of the Mortal Weave have *real, tangible power* across all planes:

- The Concordant Halls can enforce oaths made in the Engine itself
- The Living Accord can trigger ecological collapse in realms that refuse necessary endings
- The Curator Arcanum can seal knowledge that even deities cannot uncover

They are not the good guys.

A Priest of Gephorix channels the Living Accord (suffering-as-transformation).

A Combatant sworn to Azraael walks the Concordant Halls (contract-enforcement as purpose).

A Scholar who studied the Outer Black serves the Curator Arcanum (knowing what must stay veiled).

The cosmos does not reward virtue.

It rewards **commitment, balance, and willingness to hold what cannot coexist.**

Before the Infernal Schism, there was no need.

The Sovereign Realms held their own balance. Each realm had custodial structures—the Verdant Synod, the Black Reliquary, the angelic hierarchies—but these served their realms, not the cosmos. The Balance was assumed. Cosmic law was *immutable*.

Then Azraael broke the Crown.

The Crown-Breaking was not merely an infernal coup. It was **proof that cosmic law could be rewritten**. Azraael did not destroy the Engine of Bael-Zaroth's other powers—she *amended their foundational code*. She inserted herself into the final line of every contract in existence: all debt, all obligation, all binding now terminates in her name.

The shockwave propagated across every realm. Reality *thinned* at the fracture points. The Schism-Scarred were born—beings corrupted mid-existence when infernal law propagated through them. The Pact of Neutrality was hastily signed. The Roiling Crucible was sealed.

But the deeper wound had already been dealt.

Azraael had proven something that terrified even the gods: **divine law is not immutable**. One will, with sufficient cunning, could rewrite reality without destroying it. The cosmos had been *edited*.

And so the cosmos wrote back.

The Balance does not think. It does not plan. It does not punish. But it *responds*—the way an immune system responds to infection, the way a fracture responds with callus.

In the aftermath of the Crown-Breaking, something *crystallized* in the Mortal Weave that had not existed before with such clarity. The Concordant Halls, the Living Accord, and the Curator Arcanum had always governed their principles in loose, diffuse ways. But now they **solidified into Custodial Powers** with *real, enforceable authority* across all planes.

The cosmos's amendment to Azraael's amendment.

- **The Concordant Halls** became the answer to contract-tyranny: oaths that serve commitment, not exploitation
- **The Living Accord** became the answer to eternal debt: cycles that must end, transformation that cannot be hoarded
- **The Curator Arcanum** became the answer to knowledge-as-weapon: truths that should remain veiled until mortals are ready

Azraael proved the cosmos could be scarred. The Custodial Powers are the scar tissue.

Why the Mortal Weave?

Because the Mortal Weave was the only realm that did not align with any single cosmic principle. The Empyreal Accord is too lawful. The Wild Expanse is too primal. The Gloam is too final. The Engine is too *Azraael's*.

Only in the Mortal Weave—where all cosmic pressures meet as equals—could custodial structures emerge that answer to the Balance itself rather than any particular power.

Azraael wanted to be the final signature on all obligation.

The cosmos responded by creating entities whose authority she cannot amend.

The Concordant Halls can enforce oaths that supersede infernal contracts—because they serve *commitment*, not *termination in Azraael's name*.

The Living Accord can trigger endings that Azraael's eternal debt cannot prevent—because cycles must *end*, even when the Engine wants them to compound forever.

The Curator Arcanum can seal knowledge that even Azraael cannot access—because some truths are dangerous even to those who *edit reality*.

She scarred the cosmos. The cosmos wrote an amendment.

And now that amendment has become the manifestation of these ideals—three Custodial Powers that represent not *goodness*, but *balance*. Not *virtue*, but *limits*.

Even for gods. Especially for gods who thought they could rewrite everything.

Mortals are forged from Balance. That is why they wield it.

Demi-Gods of the Reflected Realms

Unlike the Mortal Weave, the Gloam and The Verge are overseen by demi-divine entities—beings of greater-than-mortal power who embody principles too extreme for mortal stewardship alone.

The Gloam Custodians

The Black Reliquary — *Keepers of the Final Accounting*

Eight masked demigods presiding over death's many truths:

- Malthex, the Ash-Hate (Hatred)
- Druvain the Pall (Dread)
- Korveth Redwake (War)
- Noctyr the Veiled (Darkness)
- Selmyra of the Second Breath (Rebirth)
- Vaelion the Quiet (Rest)
- Pyrix the Crawling Crown (Plague)
- Ulthor of the Open Scar (Suffering)

Aligned with: Aralys, Darthun, Gephorig

Role: Ensure no soul lingers beyond its narrative weight

Note: "They do not kill. They close books."

The Loom of Fates — *Archivists of Possibility*

Five veiled entities maintaining narrative causality:

- Seris Uncast (Chance)
- Ithrael the Remembered (Hindsight)
- Vorn of the Binding Word (Obligation)

- Caelis the Unbent (Will)
- Thys of the Coming Shadow (Foreshadow)

Aligned with: Alúneth, Murien

Note: "Free will exists because they allow it to strain."

The Verge Custodians

The Verdant Synod — *Custodians of Living Processes*

Six entities overseeing biological and existential transformation:

- The Chronogreen (Life-Cycles & Time)
- The Vital Weft (Growth & Healing)
- The Spark Unleashed (Energetic Expression)
- The Shifting Husk (Transformation)
- The Many-Seeded Gate (Summoning Life)
- The Far-Seer Rooted (Perception & Pattern)

Aligned with: Thymera, Murien, Aluneth

Role: Attempt to moderate the Excesses and prevent total ecological collapse when one imperative dominates for too long. They do not rule the Verge—they **tend it**, like gardeners pruning a forest that thinks for itself.

The Wheel of Ruin — *Executors of Excess*

Four entities bound into perpetual motion:

- The Breaker (Destruction)
- The Final Silence (Annihilation)
- The Storm Unbound (Havoc)
- The Returning Dust (Decomposition)

Aligned with: Gephorig, Darthun, Iosyx

Role: Destroy what grows too far. Burn what refuses to fall. When the Bloom becomes suffocation, they light fires. When the Root strangles all growth, they tear it down. They are not evil—they are **metabolic correction**.

Warning: "They were unleashed once during a Bloom that threatened to consume the Mortal Weave. Never again."

The Roiling Crucible Custodians

The Elemental Threnody — *Voices of Raw Existence*

Five ancient, semi-conscious forces predating structured reality:

- Pyrren the Everburning (Fire)
- Aeralith the Unheld (Air)
- Thalassa Deepbound (Water)
- Korrum the Unmoved (Earth)
- Eidolon Without Shape (Spirit)

Aligned with: losyx primarily; all gods secondarily
Role: Ensure reality never becomes static
Warning: "If they ever sing in unison, the Veil will tear."

—— MYTHOLOGY & LORE

[NOTE: Chapter opener illustration — The Eternal Dark as a vast formless expanse with the first cracks of light appearing. Genesis imagery: strain, tension, the moment before creation. Dark ink with gold fracture lines. Full or half-page]

Mythology & Lore

The Covenant of Balance (Creation Myth)

|| ♦ THE
COVENANT OF BALANCE ♦ || || The Creation Myth of Aeralon || || As recorded in the Forbidden Tome of
Dalamar Nidain ||

Before the Accords

Before there was form, before there was division, there was the **Eternal Dark**.

Not emptiness. Not evil. But unresolved potential—a silence so absolute that even contradiction had not yet been born.

The Eternal Dark did not hunger. It did not think. It simply **was**.

And because it was all things unchosen, nothing could begin.

The First Tension

Creation did not begin with light.

It began with **strain**.

Within the Dark, possibility folded upon itself until tension became unavoidable. From that strain emerged the first distinction:

What endures

This distinction fractured the silence and gave rise to the **Four Accords**, not as places, but as principles seeking stability.

The Four Accords Take Shape

The Empyreal Accord — Continuity

Nyroth, Aubret, and Muriel arose as anchors of permanence. They did not create—they **defined what must not fail**.

Order, memory, law, promise.

The Empyrean Accord pressed against the Dark and declared:

"This shall remain."

The Verdant Accord — Becoming

Thymera and Darthun emerged together—growth and decay entwined.

Life was not a gift. It was a **process**, violent and beautiful.

The Verge formed where change was allowed to persist without annihilation.

The Infernal Accord — Price

Where the Empyrean defined continuity and the Verdant defined change, the Infernal defined **cost**.

Azrael did not invent tyranny—she formalized consequence. Every action would now demand payment.

The Iron Hells crystallized as the place where debts could not be ignored.

The Mortal Accord — Choice

Last to stabilize was the Mortal Weave.

It was not designed, as the other three were. It was **left**.

The gods discovered that beings who lived briefly, who feared loss, who could choose wrongly—understood balance better than immortals ever could.

Thus mortals were not given dominion. They were given **responsibility**.

The Role of the Eternal Dark

The Eternal Dark was not banished.

It was **pushed back**.

It presses still against the Realms, not as an enemy, but as a reminder:

- That creation is fragile
- That certainty is dangerous
- That costs must be paid
- That balance is never permanent

Some gods fear it. Others revere it. **None control it**.

The Covenant Is Sworn

When the Accords first collided, reality trembled.

Thalos recorded the consequences. Aralys tended the first true deaths. Aluneth marked the cycles. Iosyx watched the instability and smiled.

And so the **Covenant of Balance** was sworn:

- No Accord would fully dominate another
- No god would rule the Mortal Weave directly
- No force would erase the Dark entirely

Because to do so would be the end.

The Crown-Breaking

The gods named this arrangement the **Covenant of Balance**, and swore to the **Accords** to prevent their immortal weight from unraveling it.

Where the Accord's Principles overlapped, their harmonies produced reflection rather than rule; mirrors of divine truth made imperfect by the balance of the 4th Accord.

Mortals were not a mistake, nor an accident. They are the price of balance.

In a realm where life, death, creation, and decay are held in equal measure, nothing may be eternal. Mortality is the covenant that allows the Weave to exist at all. To live fully, one must end.

One Sovereign broke the Covenant.

Azraael did not destroy the Hells—she **rewrote them**. Through the Crown-Breaking, she proved that a Plane's fundamental nature could be altered without annihilating it, creating a wound in metaphysical law itself. The cosmos has carried this wound ever since, and the Schism-Scarred are its living scar tissue.

Closing Truth

*"The gods shaped the universe,
but mortals keep it from breaking."*

The Pact of Neutrality

After **The Infernal Schism**, all higher beings of both the Inner and Outer Planes agreed to emergency containment measures. The Schism had terrified the Sovereign Powers—not because evil won, but because **one will proved capable of rewriting an entire Plane without annihilating it**.

The Roiling Crucible (Elemental Chaos) had been the vector that allowed infernal law to propagate unnoticed during the Crown-Breaking. The Pact closed it as a transit plane—not as justice, but as **containment**. The Elemental Plane would no longer be a gateway for unseen passage, only a monitored realm for study.

The Mortal Weave, seen as the only unbiased party, was tasked with creating an elite governing force—the **Interplanar Travel Network**—to ensure all parties obey the rules of the pact and prevent another reality-

altering event.

The Interplanar Travel Network

Created by the Mortal Weave as neutral arbiters following the Pact of Neutrality. This network regulates interplanar travel, which is highly controlled following the Infernal Schism. Many Planes are illegal to travel between, and numerous safeguards exist to detect metaphysical alterations to Planar law.

Most Planar travel can be accomplished by magic, but it is not advised due to regulations.

In-World Names: Mortals often refer to the Network as "**The Waylines**"—both a practical shorthand and a reminder that even paths between worlds must be monitored.

The Schism-Scarred

The Schism-Scarred are not a people granted passage, deliberately uplifted, or created by Azraael.

They are **living afterimages of the Infernal Schism**—beings from across the cosmos touched by infernal law mid-rewrite, souls that resonate slightly out of phase with the Balance. When Azraael performed the Crown-Breaking, the metaphysical shockwave rippled outward from the Engine into every realm where obligation existed. It scarred mortals, spirits, and lesser entities who stood too close to the fracture points where reality thinned—those who were signing contracts, swearing oaths, making promises, or even thinking binding thoughts at the moment the Engine rewrote itself.

They did not originate from a single world. **They came from everywhere**—the Mortal Weave, The Verge, the Gloam, even remote corners of the Sovereign Realms. Any place where someone **bound themselves to something else** became a potential fracture point.

Common Manifestations:

- Horns, tails, ember-veins, cloven feet
- Eyes that reflect contracts not yet signed
- Skin tones in shades of crimson, violet, obsidian, or ashen grey
- An instinctive understanding of loopholes, oaths, and bindings
- Some carry written text beneath their skin—clauses from the moment they were scarred

The Infernal Claim: Azraael claims the Schism-Scarred as hers. Infernal law—as she rewrote it—recognizes them as subjects of the Engine, whether they consent or not. Many Schism-Scarred feel a pull toward contracts, obligation, or rebellion—not because they serve her, but because their existence is proof that infernal law **propagates through reality itself**.

The Balance's Position: The Covenant of Balance does not recognize Azraael's claim. The Schism-Scarred are mortal (or were mortal at the moment of scarring). They die. They choose. This is the theological crisis at the heart of their existence—they are claimed by a law system that **should not apply to them**, yet resonates in their blood.

Legal Status: In 1A, after much deliberation among the Sovereign Powers, the Schism-Scarred who were pulled into the Engine's depths were granted sanctuary in the Reflected Realms through a single, heavily-

guarded portal. The portal closed shortly after and has never reopened. The Schism-Scarred now live as mortals—some reviled, some celebrated, all marked by a cosmic crime they did not commit.

Many Schism-Scarred reject Azraael entirely. Others bargain with her power out of necessity or defiance. A few embrace the claim, seeking to understand what it means to be rewritten.

The Worst Truth: Some Schism-Scarred sense they are still being **compiled**. They hear whispers of sub-clauses activating. They feel obligations they never agreed to taking root. Azraael did not just scar them—she **amended them**. And amendments can have delayed activation clauses.

Zealot Philosophies

Different religious movements interpret divine will in distinct ways:

The Bound (Nyroth / Aubreth)

Honor and law are shields against chaos. Zealots are oath-bound wardens.

The Gentle Flame (Aralys / Balemor)

Mercy is rebellion. Zealots protect the unwanted and damned.

The Living Cycle (Thymera / Darthun)

Life and death are tools. Zealots cultivate balance through harsh wisdom.

The Laughing Blade (Beryn / Muriën)

Joy defies despair. Zealots fight tyranny with story, art, and subversion.

The Chain Ascendant (Azraael)

Obligation through rewriting. Zealots seek power through finding loopholes in reality itself, believing that if Azraael can amend cosmic law, so can they. They are always wrong—she planned for that loophole centuries ago.

The Unbound (Iosyx / Zarun)

Change is sacred. Zealots shatter stagnation wherever found. Some serve cosmic transformation; others champion personal becoming.

The Downward Shield (Caerith)

Protection is mercy made manifest. Zealots guard the defenseless and hold lines others cannot.

The Weighted Choice (Thalos)

Every decision echoes. Zealots witness, record, and ensure consequences endure.

The Hearthkeepers (Ilyra)

Survival is communal. Zealots build, shelter, and maintain spaces where ordinary people endure.

The Coinbound Exchange (Korthane)

Value is agreement made sacred. Zealots broker deals, witness fair trade, and ensure all debts end. They despise eternal contracts and oppose infernal obligation.

The Ash-Taught (Velkyr)

Knowledge must be shared, even dangerous knowledge. Zealots believe truth justifies any cost. (Condemned by the Curator Arcanum.)

Marginalia of the Forbidden Tome

|| FRAGMENTS
FROM THE FORBIDDEN TOME || || Handwritten annotations by Dalamar Nidain || || ⚠ These marginalia were
found burned or partially || || erased. What remains is reproduced faithfully. ||

Fragments found in the notes of Dalamar Nidain:

- "This passage seems to contradict the Accord— almost deliberately."
- "I saw a Pale Shepherd weep. That should not be possible."
- "Do NOT speak the Nameless aloud. They listen, even when unnamed."
- "Azrael did not conquer. She rewrote. There is a difference the gods fear to name."
- "The Schism-Scarred should not exist. Their souls hum at a frequency the Balance cannot integrate. They are... errors. Living errors of a crime they did not commit."
- "The gods are not the highest powers in Aeralon. They are merely the ones who still remember why the Balance matters."

Final Note: The pages beyond this point are missing. Burned. Or erased.

About This Chronicle

[NOTE: Final page — A simple ink portrait of a Wizard opening a dark portal, light streaming from behind him. The portal leads to absolute darkness. A single open book at his feet. Bittersweet. Typography: Crimson Text italic for the colophon]

This book details the life work of the Wizard **Dalamar Nidain**, final entry written in the year **463A**.

Dalamar died a horrible death a recorded **48 times** in the writing and research for this book. He was last seen opening an illegal Planar portal into the Eternal Dark.

Dalamar was a very skilled and highly intelligent Wizard, but he was not a wise man.

—————◇—————

Compiled and organized, 467A – Reorganized by The Curator Arcanum, current date

==== END OF THE WORLD CODEX
